

CHRIS WILLIAMS

BMus (Syd), MPhil (Oxon), MA (Duke), PhD (Duke, expected 2026)

Department of Music, Duke University
Durham, USA
christopher.d.williams@duke.edu | +1 (919) 830-8242

Education and Qualifications

Duke University: PhD candidate in Music (Composition), expected 2026. **2021–Present**

- Dissertation: *Abundance and Reduction: “Between Visible and Hidden Worlds” in Composition and Music Theory*

University of Oxford: MPhil in Music (Composition), supervised by Prof. Robert Saxton **2011–13**

- Thesis: “*Consummating the Symbol: Authorial agency in the construction of musical meaning*” (supervised by Prof. Peter Franklin)

Sydney Conservatorium of Music: BMus (Composition), First-Class Honors **2006–09**

Teaching, Academic, and Professional Experience

Duke University **2021–present**

- *Teaching Assistant*

Undergraduate Course: Introduction to electronic music **2022, 2023**

Responsibilities: Marking weekly assignments; one-on-one discussions with students about projects; providing guidance and feedback; two guest lectures delivered.

- *‘Instructor of Record’/Guest Lecturer*

Undergraduate Courses: Music 261L: <i>Theory and Practice of Tonal Music I</i> Lab	2023
Music 161 <i>Introduction to Music Theory</i>	2024
Music 257: <i>Nineteenth-Century Music</i>	2025
Music 245S: <i>Musical Shakespeare</i> (Cross-listed: Theatre Arts 244S; English 229S)	2025

Responsibilities: Designed course materials; delivered lectures; devised and implemented active-learning activities; marked assessments; provided student mentoring and feedback.

- Certificate in College Teaching (CCT) in-progress **expected June 2026**
- Certificate in AI for Higher Education from Digital Education Council in-progress, **expected June 2026**
- Fellowship with Advance HE in-progress **expected June 2026**
- Teaching Triangles peer-to-peer teaching observation and mentoring **2023**

Sydney Conservatorium of Music **2018**

- *Guest Lecturer*

Course: Music Worlds of Today, *Australian Music*

Responsibilities: Wrote and delivered two lectures on Australian music; developed tutorial materials and discussion prompts. These lectures were by invitation from a former teacher of mine who was on leave.

University of Oxford

2012–13

- *Graduate Tutor*

Course: Techniques of Composition, *Exeter and St Hugh's Colleges*

Responsibilities: Designed, delivered, and assessed weekly small-group tutorials in composition, harmony, and analysis.

- *Conductor*, Worcester College Orchestra

Responsibilities: Directed weekly rehearsals; managed logistics; planned programmes, concerts, and procured music; managed budget; and served on the college music committee.

Teaching and Research Interests: Composition; Music Technology; Film Music; Music Theory and Analysis; Orchestration; Computer-Aided and Algorithmic Composition; Computer-Aided Musicology and Visualization; AI; Music History.

Additional Professional and Creative Appointments

2012–Present

Jury Member, <i>Australian Art Music Awards</i>	2019, 2024, 2025
Composer, <i>Melbourne Theatre Company</i>	2018–2019
Music Librarian, <i>BBC Music Library</i>	2017–2021
Composer, <i>Sydney Theatre Company</i>	2016–2019
Theatre/Music Critic, <i>MD Theatre Guide</i> , Washington DC	2015–2017
Peer Reviewer, <i>Directions of New Music</i> journal	2016
Creative Arts Fellow, <i>National Library of Australia</i>	2015
Project Coordinator, <i>Australian Music Centre</i> , Digitisation Project	2013–2015

Research and Creative Outputs

Creative Work (selected)

2023–25

All that's gentle turns — for Susan Fancher and the Abele Saxophone Quartet; generated using AI latent-space traversal and custom algorithms 2025

Between Visible and Hidden Worlds — large-scale orchestral work recorded by the North Carolina Symphony Orchestra; developed in response to outputs from a custom corpus and LLM 2025

A phantom attempts to sing as she once did on earth — for Anzû ensemble; developed in response to outputs from a custom corpus and LLM 2025

swift, slow; sweet, sour; adazzle, dim (orchestral version) — orchestral version recorded for the Australian Music Centre's *MOMENTUM Plus* project; premiered by Raleigh Civic Symphony; string quartet version commissioned for the Ciompi Quartet 2022, 2025

Scores published by: Australian Music Centre; MorningStar Music Publishers.

<i>we have seen it rising</i> — commissioned by Australian National Academy of Music	2023–24
<i>The true ceremony of the sun: string quartet no. 1</i> — commissioned by the Flinders Quartet	2024
<i>only dust and not a sound</i> — for the Horszowski Trio	2023
<i>Endless Radiance</i> — for Duke Chapel Choir	2023

Selected Commissions and Collaborations

2012–2023

<i>Aurora Pacifica</i> commissioned by the NSW Department of Education	2022–23
Cor anglais concerto commissioned by The Tasmanian Symphony Orchestra	2020
<i>I pray the sea</i> commissioned by The Song Company	2019–2020
<i>Strange and solemn music</i> commissioned by the Takefu International Music Festival	2018
<i>three horizons</i> commissioned through the Stefan Kruger Scholarship	2015–16
<i>Convict Monologues</i> chamber commission from Tasmanian Symphony Orchestra	2017
<i>birds(unfailing)</i> commissioned by The Chelsea and Westminster Hospital	2013
<i>San-shih-fan</i> commissioned by Carnegie Hall	2012

Peer-Reviewed and Scholarly Publications

2017–Present

“Embodied Music Theory and Improvised Composition: Bill Evans, the Architect.” *Principles of Music Composing* XVII (2017): 86–98

“Parsimony and Intercardinality through the DFT: What harmonic qualia tell us about voice leading.” In preparation for submission to *Music Theory Spectrum*.

Conference Papers and Invited Talks

2017–Present

“Parsimony and Intercardinality through the DFT” <i>Liverpool–Georgia Music Theory Colloquia</i> .	2025
“Smoothies and Whisky: A plain-language primer on the discrete Fourier transform (DFT) and its musical meanings” <i>Duke University Faculty/Student Colloquia</i>	2024
“Conceptualizing Harmonic Qualia with Fourier Spaces” <i>South Central Graduate Music Consortium (SCGMC) conference</i>	2024
“The harmonic multiverse: harmonic qualia and Scriabin” <i>SCGMC conference</i> Duke University (2022); revised and presented at <i>Scriabin@150 conference</i> Reading	2022
“Mapping Harmonic Distance and Difference: Models and Metrics” <i>BrumMAC 2021</i> , Society for Music Analysis	2021
“Sun Music, Sun Books: Historical Musicology in Service of the Nationalist Agenda” <i>17th Annual Plenary Conference of the Society for Musicology in Ireland</i>	2019
“Invited Composer Talk” <i>Takefu International Music Festival</i>	2018
“Embodied Music Theory and Improvised Composition: Bill Evans, the Architect.” <i>17th International Music Theory Conference, Principles of Music Composing</i>	2017

Public Scholarship and Writing

2020–Present

“Remembering Nigel.” Australian Music Centre, feature article	2025
---	------

- “The Society of Women Musicians: 110th Anniversary.” BBC Central Music Library, Digital Update (internal publication), March 2021
- “The BBC Symphony Orchestra at 90: The First European Tour.” *BBC History Research Blog*, 2020
- “Life on Earth: How Electronic Music Helped Us ‘See’ Nature.” *BBC Genome Blog* 2020

Awards and Fellowships

Fellowships	selected 2006–present
• Julian Price Graduate Fellowship in Humanities and History	2025–26
• CCT Computational Summer Fellowship	2025
• William Klenz Prize in Music Composition 2024 for piano trio <i>Only dust and not a sound</i> , written for the Horszowski Trio	2024
• Rose Mandelbaum Scholarship in Music and Eleanor Sophia Wood Graduate Travelling Scholarship (University of Sydney)	2011–13
• Creative Arts Fellow, <i>National Library of Australia</i>	2015
• Foundation Scholar, St Paul’s College	2006–09
• Doris Burnett Ford Scholarship (Sydney Conservatorium of Music)	2006–09

Awards

- MACRO Composition Competition, Honorable mention. 2026
- Award for Best Orchestration, *Chigiana Intensive Film Scoring Course* 2022
- Winner of the *Musica Per Archi* Composition Prize, Lviv Philharmonic 2020
- Nominee for *Best Original Score*, Sydney Theatre Awards 2018
- Winner, Composition Prize, *Australian International Chopin Competition* (2017)
- Highly Commended, *Peter Sculthorpe Music Fellowship* 2015
- Winner, *Joyful Company of Singers Young Composer Prize* 2013
- Winner, *Blake Society Tithe Grant* (adjudicated by Judith Weir) 2012

Service and Leadership

Music Graduate Student Association (MGSA), Duke University

- Executive Committee Member* 2021–Present
Led mentoring and professional development initiatives; supported incoming and international students; co-led inclusion and peer-support efforts.
- Co-Coordinator, “Talk Music” Professional Development Series* 2022–2023
Designed and facilitated workshops and invited speaker events on pedagogy, research, and public music theory. Co-led inclusion and peer-support efforts, fostering collaboration across faculty and graduate students.
- Graduate Professional Student Government (GPSG), Department Representative* 2021–2023
Advocated for student needs and served as liaison between MGSA and GPSG.
- South-Central Graduate Music Conference (SCGMC) Co-organizer* 2023–present
Collaborated across Duke, UNC, and UVA, to redesign the conference format and expand participation.